

Colt's Vegas

Las Vegas was loud and brash, flashy lights and cars stark around every street corner. Fashions that would have not had a place anywhere else in the world ran amok, the scene and the time for rash decisions. Many a fur had gotten hitched in a flurry of drunk mishaps, waking up the next morning with a cheap ring on their finger whether they were male, female or no longer sure after the events of the night. It was the lure of the city where anything could happen and one would always leave with a new story to tell for years to come. Everywhere a fur travelled through the neon and concrete, life bustled, the city never resting.

And Pax hated every second.

Sprawled on the king sized bed of his empty hotel room, the palomino equine sighed, broad chest deflating. On the other side of the wall, the clamour of his parents readying themselves for a night out with Sera, his sister returned from university for the family holiday, echoed through. Pax groaned and rolled on to his cream-coloured front, shoving his muzzle beneath the pillows. He was due to attend university in the fall, like his sister. It would help a great deal if he knew what on earth he fucking wanted to do.

The door creaked open and he flicked his tail, the white hairs silken. The other fur closed the door quietly and waited for him to speak, patiently quiet for a minute that stretched into an age. Pax tensed, the muscles in his bare back – for he'd forgone any clothing other than jogging bottoms – tensing.

Go away, go away, go away, go away...

"You sure you don't want to come, bro?"

The mare's lilting tone was unmistakable and Pax nipped his lip, glancing back to his shoulder as light filtered into his dark crevice beneath the pillow. It felt safer there than in the rat race of the outside world, too changeable to keep pace with. Why couldn't his sister leave him in peace? He swallowed a sigh.

"Nah..."

The mare padded over to the bed, her larger hooves quiet on the thick, plush carpet, and perched on the edge, resting her paw in the centre of his back. Though muscles quivered, he remained still as she stroked down his spine with hoofed fingertips, easing the tension from his body. Slowly, stroke by stroke, he relaxed into his sister's touch and pressed his muzzle into the bed, letting loose a soft nicker. She chuckled and played her fingers down to the small of his back, pausing to massage the spot above his tail.

"You didn't get ready in here?"

It wasn't much of a question but it was all Pax had for her, keeping up appearances so that she would not ask him any more questions. She would not nose if she spoke of herself, that much he knew.

"Oh..." She teased her fingers through his mane. "Yeah, mum and I were helping each other get the zippers on our dresses up. I can't twist to do it myself." She chuckled. "Kind of silly really."

Pulling his muzzle out, he blinked up at the familiar brown muzzle with the white stripe. Her blue eyes smiled at him, black mane neatly oiled and braided along the arch of her neck. She was more of a traditional, heavy set cob than he was, skin taut over muscle and weight she carried well. A kind fur would have called her 'curvaceous'. He had called her far worse as a younger, crasser colt.

"It's not silly," he said. "You don't have the flexibility to reach back. But I could have helped if you'd asked."

"Why?" Her eyes brightened. "Did you want me to daub eye shadow on you too? You'd look so *pretty* for all the hot mares out there!"

He grunted and rolled his eyes, avoiding the bait. He had only been caught with his mother's make-up *once* when he was very young and he didn't think he would ever hear the end of the story. It would go on and on and on and on until it was finally told at his wedding day, or so he had been playfully threatened. He didn't doubt that his family would pounce on the opportunity to embarrass him but he didn't think that he would have a wedding either, not with how he was as a stallion.

Pax shook himself. There was no time for those thoughts.

Sitting up, he looked his sister over, momentarily blinded by the sparkles on her dress. The little red number had more sequins than fabric and he stifled a snort, clapping a paw over his muzzle a moment too late. The mare sat back, painted red lips twisting as she tilted her head, her brother's eyes too wide and innocent to be believed.

"What?"

Sera frowned, crossing her arms over her breasts and thankfully hiding her plunging bosom. Slowly, so as not to lose control and burst into giggles, Pax swung his legs over the edge of the bed as his sister rose to take a step back, eyes sharp.

"Don't you think you want to...I don't know..." Pax tried to be tactful. "Go for something a little less...loud?"

She wrinkled her muzzle, ears twitching.

"What are you trying to say, little brother?"

He flinched. He hated when she called him that, yet Sera insisted. It was better not to make a scene, even though she was only one year older than him. Sera was formidable to say the very least of her attitude. And colts were liable to become tongue tied, hoof-in-mouth disease a common problem amongst his kind. Pax swallowed hard and brushed his forelock out of his eyes, long lashes catching on the soft strands of hair.

"Nothing at all," he said, lips curved into a smile, the picture of innocence. "But you look beautiful tonight. Only the best stallion would be able to match up to you and give you what you deserve."

Though heat flushed her cheeks, the mare looked away, rubbing her forearm in a distracting motion. Embarrassment, however, did not suit her features well and the sly gleam in her eye swiftly returned, a paw on her hip as she jutted it out cockily.

"Well, my taste leans more towards felines lately." She grinned and brought her finger to her lips in a 'shush' gesture. "Something about the claws... They feel fantastic when they prick into my --"

"Sera!"

Pax shot to his hooves, holding his paws up and shaking his head hard enough for his neck to hurt. If he had been younger, he would have held his paws over his ears and mumbled nonsense so as not to be forced to hear of his sister's exploits. Sera could be graphic at the best of times and he didn't want to know what she would say with the aroma of her first Long Island of the night on her breath.

"Don't sound so shocked, little brother," Sera laughed. "Maybe we'll find you a nice lady yet. She doesn't have to be a horse, no matter what mom and dad say. Species doesn't matter as much as they say and the world is changing..."

Her eyes grew distant and she stared over his shoulder. The mare tucked an imaginary strand of hair behind her ear, even though her mane had not a hair out of place.

"I mean..." Words spilled forth. "What does species matter, really, when you think about it? I mean, really think about it. We're all furs, aren't we? We're not like our four-legged kind, the ones that don't have our intelligence. Silly things. Bad luck of the draw. We're evolved. Why should it matter who we choose to spend our lives with when the curtains close?" She closed her eyes. "At the end of the day?"

Pax twitched, tail flicking against the bed as he stood and stretched his arms above his head. Sera's ramble was not meant for his ears, yet he let her continue anyway, working out the idea in her head. He was not the one that anyone had to worry about ending up with another fur, but that was an issue for Sera to work through herself, if his suspicions were correct. Nothing for a brother to pry into, unless his opinion was desired. And Sera had never wanted that before.

The stallion touched his sister's arm, halting her stream of vocalised thought, and nickered, bumping his nose into her cheek. She trembled, eyes glazed with the sheen of tears. The stallion's jaw clenched. That cat, whoever he was, better treat her right. Or else there'd be hell to pay from the so called 'little brother' himself.

"Whatever you choose, it shouldn't matter to anyone else," he said, feeling older than his years told. "Mother and father won't mind who you're with, you know. You're the trial run, after all." His eyes glinted. "You know. As you're the oldest. They get to make all their mistakes on you."

"Why – you!"

Sera thumped him, muzzle dropped into an 'O' of shock that could not be concealed behind shivering mirth. Swatting at her brother, she threw her paws in the air and huffed, half-turning away from the stallion with a sullen flick to her tail. For a moment, Pax almost felt bad. Almost.

"Come on, Sera," Pax said, sidling closer. "You know I don't mean it. Just trying to cheer you up. It was a joke, silly. Stop sulking. Please? For me? For your *little brother*?"

He pouted, lips pushed out and trembling false from his muzzle, the image of a scorned colt. It didn't take much for her to come around and she joined him in chuckling, bosom trembling with amusement. The stress melted from her shoulders and Sera giggled, a lock of hair falling loose from its braid into her eye.

"You're an idiot, you know that?"

She looked her brother up and down with perfectly made-up eyes, mascara curled and spreading her lashes delightfully. The mare cocked an eyebrow, lips twisting into a half-smile that did not rise on the other side of her muzzle. She blew her brother a kiss and spread her arms wide, fingers curling in to beckon him closer. He shook his head but it was already too late as she forced him into the hug.

"Still short," she teased, drawing him in tight, chin tucked atop his head. "When are you going to hit your growth spurt, hey, little brother? Surely you're due for it by now?"

"I've already hit it," he grumbled, squirming as he strove to escape her iron grip. "Bloody lay off, would you? You know I don't bleeding do this, Sera – let *go*."

She stepped back, ears slanted to the sides. Her expression flickered and he caught the briefest flash of the wounded before painting her face carefully cool, smile not reaching her eyes.

"Well...okay then," Sera said levelly. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to upset you. Just was teasing."

She shrugged, smile fixed. Turning for the door, she made as if to leave without another word. The spring vanished from her step and Pax stood with his paws held awkwardly at his sides, frozen in place until shock kicked his numb mind into action. He launched into action, scrabbling after her and tripping over his own hooves. He flung out his paw, his sister too far away already, just like she'd always been.

"Wait – Sera! Please! Hold on a second!"

Pausing at the door, she half-glanced back, tail swishing sadly. Her lipstick had smudged on to her perfectly white teeth.

"Maybe one day you won't push us away so," she said. "But I didn't think a hug would be too much to ask. Jokes aren't so bad either. You should learn to take a joke. You

used to joke with me before.” She sighed. “I’m sorry you don’t like to be close to me. Pushed you too far. I know you don’t mean it. Not really.”

Pax stared dumbly at her. It was just a hug he’d turned down – was that so serious? How could someone take that so badly? Pax gulped, misunderstanding her perception of the situation. Who wanted to be clamped to their sister’s breasts? He didn’t like breasts! Was that so weird after all that’d happened? Of course bloody not! He fumbled for words, tongue tied. The stallion growled mentally, ears flat against his skull.

“I don’t want to push you away...but...wait...Sera?”

Pax shook his head as the mare disappeared, closing the door without another word. And, just like that, the room was once again empty but for the sound of his own breathing. Her hooves faded down the hallway, the mare gone off. It seemed that she had little care remaining for him as they aged. The stallion rubbed the back of his paw, shock melting into stomach-churning upset. Spine-chilling sadness flooded him to the tips of his fingers as if he had been plunged into a black pit.

The stallion scrunched up his muzzle, fighting down emotion. He was stronger than that. He was meant to be stronger. He shouldn’t feel sad. He should be running after his sister, finding out what exactly was wrong. He should be apologising.

Should, should, should – he fucking hated that word.

The stallion pressed his paws over his muzzle, rubbing his knuckles into the sockets of his eyes. Why were things so complicated? Was there any understandable reason? He had not meant to hurt her. It was half her fault, though Sera had always said she was not to blame. Pax gritted his teeth together. Would no one consider his feelings?

Anger flared, licking through his veins with an old, familiar heat. The stallion’s back stiffened and he curled his paws into fists, containing it as it built, second by agonising second.

And then he snapped, teeth clicking physically together as if he had become a feral equine, losing himself to baser instincts. What the fuck did she think he had done wrong? He’d never liked anyone clinging to him – it was annoying! Even before! Why did she think that was going to change? Why did it matter to anyone? It was his fucking deal to deal with how he wanted to deal with it!

He stomped, bringing his hooves down on the carpet with undue force and gouging strips of material from the base layer. Kicking over the chair beside the small desk, he slammed his palms into the wall, beating the same spot until the heels of his paws throbbed with pain and breath came in heaving, crazed gasps.

Sera. It was all because of *Sera*. She picked on everything and took everything personally. He’d helped her! He’d cheered her up again! And what had she done? Thrown a hissy fit because he didn’t want to cuddle up like a lovebug! He pressed his forehead to the wall, snorting moist breath over the neutral cream paint. It was all the same, complaints and tantrums over nothing... Like all the other fucking times! Didn’t she know she already had it made? So why did she have to stick her nosy mug into his life?

He wheeled about, the whites of his eyes showing as he took stock of his anger, nostrils flaring. He knew he was going too far. Yet he was too far gone to turn back. The stallion snarled a curse to the empty room and launched a kick that threw him off balance, adding fuel to the fire.

Why did she get to have her whole life worked out for her? Sera had known for, like, forever what she’d wanted to do! Excelling in the sciences, she had always known that she wanted to work in medicine and was well on her way to becoming a doctor – one of the best, if her confidence in her exam scores was to be believed. And he did believe her, even if he did not want to. She was Sera. She was his sister. She had everything worked out.

And he didn't. Not one bit. While she hated who he was. The sister he just wanted a shard of approval from, as sharp as it could be.

The anger seeped away as if through a drain in the floor beneath his hooves. His tail flattened to his rump as if for protection, though against what he did not know.

Pax stood in the centre of the room, chest heaving and sweat darkening patches on his golden coat. His back was sticky. He rolled his shoulders but only found a twinge in his chest. It was wrong to go off on Sera so much, yet he felt too much had happened for him to make peace with her. Stuff that she had no idea about, not in its true form, though still tackled clumsily. She had to stick her nose in. Even if she wanted him to be better, at her heart, she regardless wanted to change him.

Pax sighed, exhausted now that anger had deserted, muscles trembling as if pushed upon by an exterior force. He unclenched his paw slowly, watching tendons move beneath the thinner coat of hair, clipped close to the skin. Every bone in his body ached, pain thrumming too deep for it to ever be massaged out with the gentlest caresses his mind could dream up. That was why he did not touch. Touch came harshly. And yet there was no one that could understand that.

He closed his eyes. Some pain was buried too far down for it to be dug up. He was yet to find good reason to look back.

Pax's eyes snapped open as he straightened, the natural curve returning to his spine. Standing around would do no good! At least he had not shouted at Sera. He could be proud of himself for keeping his head until then. And there was no sense in making himself feel worse. There was only one place that helped when he felt like this.

Muscles aching as if in anticipation, dug around the pale, wooden wardrobe for his battered gym bag. His parents, bless them, had said it was silly to take a gym bag on holiday but he had known he would need it. The palomino equine licked his lips and fished out the black and yellow backpack, checking that his gloves were safely tucked inside. It wasn't obsession that drove him to the gym, breaking down muscle so that the fibres would re-grow stronger. He inhaled deeply. The gym was not silly and neither was it vain, as others claimed.

It was his safety net.

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Flat on his back on a bench under a half-rack and loaded barbell, Pax huffed, panting for breath lost in the expenditure of energy. His black vest clung to his cut chest, muscle swelling proudly, and his paws hung down to the padded floor on either side of the bench. He put an arch into his back, easing out the strain after completing the last bench press repetition. The pain was a good pain.

Lucky this hotel has a reasonably well equipped gym, he thought, casting around the wall to wall matting, suitable for heavy lifting. For a one-off expense, it would have set the hotel back but Las Vegas was a place where extravagance reigned. So it was good that lavish spending extended to the gym as he preferred to spend most of his time in one.

He curled his fingers around the cool metal, the bar weight twenty kilos, and tensed his muscles expectantly. Pax paused and sniffed, muzzle wrinkling in distaste. His gloves were starting to stink again. Pax smirked at the fleeting thought of shoving them in Sera's gaping muzzle later. That would be a brotherly thing, an acceptable thing, to show her, to teach her a 'lesson' no one would raise an eyebrow at.

He pushed the bar from the hooks and took the weight on his paws, arms shivering as if they would collapse under the weight of the plates slotted neatly on to either end of the bar. Bending his elbows, he pushed his chest up and brought the bar down to graze his chest, muzzle contorting. He strained, grunted, and made it rise, a push up to the top that raked

breath through his lungs, muscles burning. It was an addictive sensation. Completing one rep, he did it again and again, driving the bar up with the cleanest form he could muster until eight repetitions had been squeezed from his tired body.

There was only one other in the gym and, in the middle of his set, Pax's skin tingled. Forcing himself to complete the set without interruption, he re-racked the bar and sat up, head spinning; it took a lot of effort to push his body past its limit. He looked straight into the eyes of another equine beside the long rack of dumbbells, a male more heavily muscled than he. The black horse with a thick, black mane and tail blinked, startling green eyes fixed on Pax. He held a dumbbell in each paw, though was not close enough for Pax to discern how heavy each of them were.

Pax tried not to stare but, if the other fur was going to be rude, he saw no reason to maintain his manners. Pushing his paws out from his chest, he worked out the soreness from his triceps: they needed a lot more work than he had time to give them. He did not rub the ache in his chest, however, thinking it would be strange to do it when another was staring point blank at him.

The black stallion replaced his pair of dumbbells on the long rack. Pax huffed and brushed his forelock from his eyes.

Oh, *fuck*, he was coming over!

Playing it cool – he hadn't been giving him the eye, not really, he hadn't! – Pax rubbed his arm, wishing belatedly that he had something other than a vest top on. It was an overly showy look for gym-goers, but he'd reckoned, hey, he could get away with it on holiday. Now he wished he'd gone for his usual scruffy t-shirt, a damn side less embarrassing.

Pax fidgeted as the horse approached, eyes bright. The stallion swallowed. How was it possible to have eyes that blue? He was probably another vain stallion who thought he was a stud and wore contacts to make the mares swoon. That thing about 'piercing blue eyes' and all that jazz. Pax snorted.

"You're looking pretty good there," the stallion offered, stopping a respectful distance away. "Nice form."

Pax's ears pricked and he leaned forward, grabbing his water bottle with one paw. Buying time, he took a drink, water dribbling down his chin.

"I thought it was an unspoken rule of the gym not to interact," Pax commented dryly when he had thought of what he deemed to be a good enough response for the moment.

Water dripped off the whiskers on his chin and his lips twitched in imitation of a scowl. The damn things needed trimming again and itched something awful. The black horse chuckled and shook his head, blue eyes sharp with something unknown that set Pax on edge, heart racing.

"I suppose so," he conceded. "But it's quiet enough and you couldn't claim that this is a strict training gym. Rules are different here, or so I'll say myself."

Pax scratched his neck, considering.

"It's well enough equipped for training," he said, gaze sweeping the room. "Not just filled with cardio machines. No full power cage but I'm grateful for whatever I get in hotels."

"Well equipped? You think so?" The horse's ears twitched and his forelock fell over one eye. "Thanks. I'm kind of responsible for that."

Pax leaned back, uncomfortable with how the other horse towered over him, though was not comfortable enough to stand either. He warranted that the equine was a good head taller than him, draft blood rife.

"How are you responsible?"

"I work here," he answered simply. "Managed to get the boss to put in better equipment." He laughed, a full-throated rumble. "Could you believe that they had little pink dumbbells in here before? What good are those for anyone?"

His laugh was infectious and, unconsciously, Pax chuckled along, tail flicking against the bench. Taking a step to the side, the horse leaned on Pax's half-rack, taking the weight off one hoof.

"Small dumbbells aren't that bad," Pax said once the chuckles subsided. "Good for drop sets, burnouts or stuff like that... Light weight really kills for some bastard lifts, however small."

The black horse nodded, a fresh glimmer of respect in his eyes.

"What's your name then?"

"Pax." Pax held out his paw. "Good to meet you."

Shaking his paw in a firm grip, the stallion eyed him levelly.

"Pax..." He repeated the name. "I'm Diego. And the pleasure is all mine, believe me."

Pax released Diego's paw, fingers brushing as they separated. It was strange how, for males, physical contact was restricted. Anything more than a one-armed hug, paw shake or slap on the shoulder was reason to cough in quiet discomfort. For a stallion disliking physical contact at the best of times, a paw shake was about the most he could manage without flinching away, laughing to treat his retreat as a jest. He had the routine perfected for those who did not know him closely. Contact was to be limited.

So why did his heart abnormally, fervently? His fingers tingled as if struck by a static shock; he curled and uncurled them to make the sensation disappear. He ran his fingers through his mane, an awkward silence falling between the two stallions, and swallowed.

Diego coughed into his paw, long forelock half-covering his muzzle. Pax wondered how the stallion managed to keep it so lengthy without it winding him up every second of every waking hour.

The stallion regained his wandering attention with a swish of his tail that sent the strands flying in a smooth, hypnotic arc.

"So..." Diego scratched behind his ear. "I've pestered you for long enough. I'd best let you get back to your workout. If you need any help, give me a shout, all right?" He smiled. "After all, I am a trainer. That's what I'm here for, if you fancy it."

Pax nodded, something that he could not explain sending a twinge through his chest. The horse was good company, even in their short time chatting. He made Pax relax, muscles unknotting in a sensation that was both relieving and eerily foreign.

"Yeah...sure. I'll give you a shout."

With a flick of his tail, Diego made his way back to the other side of the gym, pausing for a split second to check his reflection in the mirrors stretching the length of the room. Hiding his smile, Pax let his body fall back on the bench, shoulder blades absorbing the impact as he raised his paws to the bar. It was suddenly a very lonely bar, despite being loaded with the same style plates that he always used. Across the gym, Diego grunted, working his way through a set of something Pax couldn't quite catch from his position. Pax snorted at the bar. Maybe the horse would come back over in some time. Chit-chat was not *that* much of a faux pas.

Or, if it was, he could make an exception. For a *Diego*.

He narrowed his eyes, focusing on the bar as he took the weight and brought it down to his chest so that he could not think of a silly horse with whom he had exchanged a few words. Arms burning, Pax glared the bar up, working through the repetitions with unrivalled dedication. It helped, soothing his mind, if but for a time.

When Pax came up from his final set, he raised an eyebrow at what the strange equine had clasped in his paw, eyes returning unwaveringly to Diego. While most carried a notebook

to the gym or logged exercise on their mobile phone, he had a pack of playing cards in his pocket. Diego selected seven cards from the deck and flipped them over simultaneously. Choosing one, Diego nodded, laid it face-up on the end of a bench and selected dumbbells from the larger end of the rack. With a set of weights that would have made Pax's muscles scream and fail, the stallion hung his arms down to his sides and lifted his shoulders in a shrug, working the traps across his upper back. His muzzle twisted in a grimace and Pax stifled a chuckle. He was just as bad for making faces during that exercise.

Pax licked his lips as his mouth abruptly ran dry. He could not hold a handle to the weight Diego was using and doubted he ever would. He simply did not seem to be built for pushing and pulling heavier loads with his upper body, carrying greater strength in his legs. It was a shame when most males focused on the upper body, the chest and biceps. He wanted to match up with them too. He wanted others males to look at him in the same way he looked at them. Pax exhaled, pressing his fingers between his eyes. A headache was well on its way.

Maybe, however... The horse pondered, ignoring the background grunts and huffs. Maybe the stallion had something good in his training regime that he could share with Pax? Something to break his plateau and push him further? He was a trainer and more experienced while Pax rarely had any assistance when it came to the gym. The equine learned as he went along, utilising all the videos and free help that he could find, as privately as he could find it. Personal training was an unaffordable luxury to a colt on the precipice of emptying his wallet further for study.

He shouldn't interrupt someone in the gym, he had said so himself. Diego probably didn't even want to talk to a gangly colt. He was in a completely different league, ripped with only the tiniest sliver of bulk-gut showing through his grey t-shirt. The stallion stood to unload the bar while he considered the idea of requesting help, a foreign notion to his solitary mind. It didn't seem to make sense in his head, logic twisting so far that he could not recognise fact from fiction.

With the plates stored safely on the rack, Pax clapped his paws on his thighs. What the hell. He would likely enough never see the stallion again. So fuck logic. Fuck whatever he thought. Where was the bloody harm, hey?

Stifling nerves, Pax carted his gym bag to the other side of the gym, approaching Diego at a brisk clip of a walk. His blonde mane clung to his crest, strands soaked with sweat, and he arched his neck, petal-shaped ears pricked to the grunts of a stallion working hard. Finishing his set, Diego dropped the weights carefully on the matted floor and flexed his fingers to work out soreness. Pax sympathised with his pain.

"Hey."

Diego started, shuddering back for a fraction of a second in surprise. Pax grinned and chuckled, nostrils trembling as his mirth melded into an equine whinny of pure amusement. Diego joined him, rubbing his palms together, and dug out his pack of cards, gaze raised expectantly to the palomino.

"What's up?"

"Wondering what you've got there...and it's quiet enough to be a pest today and ask." Pax justified himself aloud. "Is that a routine you follow? How does it work?"

"I think you'll find that I was the one being a pest," Diego said, flashing Pax a set of startlingly white teeth. "But this is something like...hm... How much time have you spent in Vegas? Do you know what the game *Lucky Sevens* is?"

"*Lucky Sevens*?" Pax tilted his head to one side. "Yes, but those are different – curls. Three sets of each the upper, lower and full motion for a bicep. I worked them in not too long ago."

Diego half-shrugged and flipped the red backs of the cards over to reveal the face detail.

"I know of those but haven't used them in a while. No, this 'routine' is like the game."

Pax studied the cards, each listing a different exercise in neat font with a number in the top right corner. The equine's brow furrowed.

"So...how exactly do you use these?"

Diego thumbed over the cards, sleek paper worn and curling in the corners of some if not most.

"It's simple. Like the game *Lucky Sevens*, you have to draw your selection of 'coasters' – shuffled, of course – and flip them over. The one with the highest number, or difficulty rating, is the exercise you have to complete."

He tapped his fingers across the cards and drew one to demonstrate.

"This bench press card has a score of eight but the card for leg curls scores one. If these were my choices, bench press would win."

"But that looks like..." Pax paused, looking over the cards. "All the harder exercises have higher scores against them, the compound movements. Wouldn't that make a workout very difficult? And full body?"

The stallion nodded, ears twitching as if he was pleased that Pax had caught on so swiftly.

"Yeah, it's meant to be difficult, one to make me think and work every muscle, not just in lifts. I find some yoga and Pilate things a dick to complete too. It's designed for a long, hard session," he said with a coltish grin. "Just like certain other activities..."

Pax raised an eyebrow, yet made no comment. He'd been told that he had a dirty mind – by Sera – and didn't want to read too much into Diego's words, even if the image that jumped into his mind was that of Diego pounding away with quick repetitions, hips thrusting. Swallowing, the equine tried to refocus.

"Okay, that makes sense, was just curious. Hope I didn't interrupt."

"Not at all!" Diego pushed his forelock out of his eyes. "What brings you to Vegas if you're not enjoying yourself at the casinos then?"

Pax grimaced, tucking his tail in close to his rump.

"I'm here with my family, it's supposed to be one last blowout..." He hesitated, combing his fingers through his mane. "But I'm not really into gambling. Not my scene at all."

"Seems daft to bring you then. And not much of a family holiday to me."

"Not really, but sometimes you don't have much of a say in these things."

"No?" Diego perched on the bench, this time looking up to Pax, eyes alight with genuine interest. "Why's that?"

Pax started to say something and stopped, searching for words. It was a fact – of course he didn't have a choice with his parents. They were his parents and it would be ungrateful to not accept a holiday with them. It was expected of him.

"Well, I'll be working out what I want to do with my life soon, college finished two months ago and I'm just waiting on my results. They may not see me so much anymore when I move out, though god knows where I'm going. Supposed to be off to university, like my sister, but..."

Trailing off, Pax rolled his shoulders in a shrug.

"It doesn't matter. I'm sorry for going on. Just want to be out of there and away, you know? But how do you get somewhere when you don't know where you're going? Too much has happened already."

He rubbed the back of his paw across his muzzle, avoiding the stallion's eyes.

"I shouldn't be going on about this, I'm sorry."

“Hey.” Diego rose and squeezed Pax’s shoulder, fingers curling around. “It’s okay. Sounds like you need a listening ear and someone to unload with. I can listen.”

Twisting his body so that Diego’s paw fell away, the stallion scratched his jaw. He’d only met Diego a short while ago – he couldn’t say anything for his character or for his level of judgement. He was good in the gym though and knew his stuff, that much was strictly certain. The stallion observed Pax as he mulled over his thoughts, taking longer to reply than was polite.

“You don’t like being touched so much, do you?”

Pax looked at Diego’s paw, returning to his side, unaware that he had even pushed him away.

“Eh... I didn’t mind that, not so much,” he said, waving his own paw to reassure. “It’s an automatic reaction now, didn’t mean to shove you back.”

“And why would you push someone away for putting their paw on your shoulder, unless you really didn’t want them to touch you?”

Diego took a half-step back and Pax held up his paws, shaking his head quickly to reassure.

“It’s not that I don’t want you touching me...I mean...wait. That came out wrong.” His cheeks flushed with heat. “I just don’t like *some* furs touching me. It’s nothing against you. Not so much against guys either.” He sighed. “Just female furs, usually. They’re way more touchy than blokes.”

“Why wouldn’t you want a lady touching you? That’s far from what I expected.”

The palomino stallion folded his arms, muscles tightening and unconsciously making him appear larger and stronger than he was solely from his stature. Pax tapped his fingers on his bicep, drumming across his still damp coat.

“What did you expect?”

Diego smiled sheepishly.

“Maybe that you’d been beaten up at school?” He suggested. “I wasn’t the most popular there either and got in a lot of fights. That’s why I ended up at the gym, to make sure I won any fights that others started. Raw power did well enough to keep the idiots off my back, though I had to work harder at self-defence after they started ganging up on me. Was older by then. College, school done with.” He shrugged. “As I said, not the most popular a few years ago. Doing much better now. It’s a better place and a better time for me.”

Pax’s eyes widened. He would never have guessed that about the stallion who exuded the air that he had it all figured out, just like his sister. Only not in her arrogant manner. *Everything was in paw, thank you very much, move along, please.* Pax shook his head, looking at the stallion with renewed respect. He’d done right by himself, taken care of himself, despite his words ringing true of a hard time.

Diego scooped up his water bottle and took a long, deep swig of the clear liquid within. Without stopping his rough gulps, he sat and patted the bench beside him, taking his fill of water until Pax perched alongside, hesitant to seat himself comfortably. Shouldn’t he be getting back to his routine or something? It felt wrong to use a gym bench as a conversational seat.

Wiping the back of his paw across his lips, Diego bumped Pax’s shoulder with his, a light, fleeting contact that the equine didn’t have time to move away from. It felt good to touch, sometimes, and he smiled. Diego put him at ease.

“So, are you going to tell me what’s going on in that head of yours, colt?”

He looked down at his paws, fingers curled around the edge of the bench. Did he dare? Was it wise? Diego had opened up to him. Pax rubbed his throat, taking his time to come up with the right answer, whatever that was. The only problem in the situation and life was that there was all too often no right answer. Like his choices in life ahead, university and

so forth, he had no set path to follow. He may only gain guidance from sharing with another who could offer a guiding paw.

The stallion groaned inwardly. Why couldn't things ever be fucking simple?

Diego blinked, the one blue eye that Pax could see rounding large and kind. His fingertips grazed Pax's thigh through his jogging bottoms as he replaced his bottle on the floor. Where his fingers touched, Pax's nerves sparked with electric heat. The colt shuddered, yet did not shuffle away. What was this?

He shook himself. There was no time like the present to give something a try and, to be frank, where was the harm in speaking with Diego? If he laughed or said anything untoward, Pax did not have to see him again. Their contact could be fleeting, no strings attached. He took a deep breath, nostrils flaring as air rushed into his lungs.

"A long time ago, or at least it seems like a fucking age ago, my sister, Sera, set me up with one of her friends." The words spilled out, beyond Pax's control now that he had begun. "It was nice. Nice at first. She was a mare, so of the same species, no issues raised there. Mom and dad liked her. They said we made a good couple. I was just turned fifteen, her eighteen."

Listening silently, Diego rested his paw on Pax's shoulder, putting the weight of his paw down over the course of several seconds. Pax trembled but appreciated the time allowed to become used to the sensation. It was reassuring, though the word did not encapsulate the true comfort it emanated.

"I was too young for it – maybe some stallions get it on when they're younger but, in hindsight...it wasn't right. Hindsight is twenty-twenty, after all. Looking ahead is tunnel vision. She wanted to bed me and, well, she did. Repeatedly."

Pax closed his eyes, gym lights too bright through his shadowed eyelids.

"When I didn't want to anymore – couldn't even get it up sometimes, s'pose that speaks volumes – she tied me down and made me do it, made me perform."

He hung his head, mane falling down the arch of his neck. There was not a sound in the gym besides their soft breathing, chests rising and falling out of unison.

"No one believes a bloke," Pax said, voice lowering to a whisper. "They think we want it all the time. But it's not fucking true. It would have been different, if it had been the other way round. Can only imagine how quickly furs would have leapt to my defence. But no one has time to defend a stallion against a mare. Maybe it would have been fine, if I'd been older. Could have learned from it. But...no."

Diego's paw tightened on the stallion's shoulder. Without thinking, Pax covered Diego's paw with his own for a few seconds. He could not hold the touch, however, and moved away too soon, tail swishing as Diego leaned in closer, comforting Pax without words that would not convey what could never be said.

"So...that's the truth of it," he finished, splaying his paws flat on his thighs. "That's why I don't like others being clingy with me. Mostly comes out with female furs, as they're cuddlier than guys. Always want to touch, touch and touch some more. Guys feel safer to me. If they push you too far, you're always open to retaliate."

Pax heaved a sigh.

"It's all rather stupid, I don't know what you must think of me. Shouldn't have ever let it happen, got in too deep and...I couldn't get out. Tried to tell my sister and she said I had to have been lying, told me off for screwing her friend as if she had never dragged me into it." The stallion grunted. "This all must sound fucking nuts."

"It makes sense," Diego said, quick to reassure and slide his paw around to the stallion's opposite shoulder for a one-armed hug that he released Pax from before he had the opportunity to feel uncomfortable. "I'm very sorry that happened to you. Some furs don't understand the effect they have, the influence, constantly chasing their own, selfish needs."

It's the way of it, but that doesn't mean we have to sit here and like it. Sadly, there's not many words that can help."

He licked his lips, finding the desired words.

"Only, I will say that you didn't deserve this, not one bit. It wasn't your fault, Pax. I hope you can understand that one day."

They sat there in companionable silence, Pax rubbing circles into the back of his own paw. It had been good to finally say everything aloud without being interrupted by eye rolls. The words had not many, yet their meaning beyond comprehension. Pax exhaled, releasing a breath that he had not realised he had been holding. Was it really not his fault? That was a question for another day. For now, it was relieving to have everything in the open and, temporarily, out of his head.

Diego clapped, the sharp sound startling the stallion whose ears flattened to his skull. The stallion dropped him a wink and a knowing smile that told more than his actions.

Trust me.

"Come on!" Diego offered his paw and Pax took it after a moment's hesitation, allowing Diego to pull him up to his hooves. "You may not have had the best few years since then but life is what you make of it. You're in the gym, so I'll call this therapy of a different ilk. Just like *Lucky Sevens*. *Diego therapy!*"

Though his tone was jokey, the stallion's eyes rang serious.

"Get in the half-rack, move the bench. We're doing squats."

Wordlessly, Pax complied, scooting the bench that he'd used earlier – had so much been said in such a short span of time? – and set the hooks for the barbell so that the bar would cross below his collarbone. Set up ready for Diego, the stallion glanced back, tail swishing curiously. Just what did the horse have in mind? Squats certainly had not been what he was expecting after spilling his life story, or at least a notable part, but the stallion seemed to have something in mind. He was full of surprises, it had to be said. Diego nodded encouragingly, eyes bright.

"Go on, load up your working weight."

Pax loaded the plates on the bar to a respectable weight and attached the clamps to keep them from sliding off. Not waiting for further instruction, he popped his head under the barbell and put it across his back on his traps, only then looking back with a little trepidation.

Diego took up position behind Pax in the place of a traditional spotter who would support the weight and assist with the trainee's form as and when required. Though he shuddered at having the warmth of the stallion so close, Pax gulped and stared at the wall, resolution hardening. Diego huffed breath over the back of his neck, edging closer.

"Go on, start your set and work to your best reps," Diego said. "Don't mind me – I won't touch unless you're about to drop the weight. Safety pins are in place, don't worry."

Breathing deeply and evenly, Pax set the bar more comfortably on his traps and took a step back, allowing the weight to settle. Diego moved with him, ensuring that he did not get in the way, and nickered encouragingly. He sunk into his first squat, back flat and rump pushing out, grunting with the effort it took to rise even that first time. It was too fucking heavy! He'd overestimated what he would be able to do – yet again.

He shook his head, mumbling that he couldn't squat the weight and moved to put the bar back on the hooks, intending to reduce the number of plates on the bar. But Diego wasn't having any of that. Diego held him in position, supporting the bar so that he did not topple his charge off balance with the force applied.

"Nope – it's not that easy to give up with me. Keep going. One more. Again."

Pax ground his teeth until his jaw ached, exhaling sharply as pain ripped through his muscles. He couldn't do it – it was too heavy! How was any horse supposed to lift that? The bar tilted and Diego nudged it back into position with his fingertips as Pax sank into a low

squat and, somehow, stood with the weight. The bar bent, bowing across his back, and Pax grunted, renewed determination rekindling in his chest.

Diego huffed against his mane, close, paws assisting with the lightest of guiding touches wherever they were needed. He only had to keep the colt squatting.

“Every time you stand up with the weight on your shoulders, you’re showing those bitches what for,” Diego growled in Pax’s ear, fingertips brushing the bar as he faltered on his last clean rep but not taking the weight away. “This is *you* smashing through and coming out stronger the other side. Not everything happens for a reason but you can learn from it! Pushing iron is the cure you’ve chosen, so make that bastard bar *move*!”

And, just like that, the bar rose for an eighth repetition, three more reps than Pax had ever managed at that weight working solo. He pushed the bar back on to the hooks and whinnied, the sound shrill and proud as his tail flagged, reminding him of a different kind of high. It was only one set, one to begin with, but it was a start, a beginning. Rolling his shoulders, Pax looked down at his paws, palms stinging. Something slipped from his shoulders with that lift and it was not the bar. He had not failed. He had *won*.

Or would win, one step and one day at a time. He was not so coltish as to think all was at his heels already. Yet his hooves were now on solid ground. Behind him, chest brushing Pax’s straightened back, Diego nickered and clapped his shoulder, congratulating him with a rough little shake that Pax could not help but laugh breathless at.

“Thanks...” Pax panted, tongue thick in his mouth as he dragged air into his lungs. “That helped. I think.”

“You’re more than welcome, colt.” Diego lipped his mane affectionately. “But it’s not a one-off cure. This is only to show you that you can achieve whatever you put your mind to. You only have to put in the time and work. Some help doesn’t go amiss either, if you can find a stallion as delightful as yours truly.”

Pax chuckled, glancing at the stallion as the male moved in a sudden burst of motion, angling his body away. Pax’s ears twitched and he half-turned to follow him. Why was he holding himself in such an awkward position, back hunched as if to hide? Was the equine...blushing? Pax shook his head. It had to be a trick of the light. Diego wouldn’t blush. How silly to think such a thing.

Diego shifted uncomfortably, but there was one thing that a stallion could never conceal. Though it took him several agonisingly long moments to come to his senses, Pax’s eyes dropped to the obvious bulge in the equine’s jogging bottoms, tenting out the front as a half-hard shaft proudly dropped. Pax’s jaw fell slack as Diego whickered, hiding his searing muzzle. Pax *stared*.

It caught him off-guard, a burning flash of heat that made his tail swish, sheath plumping out with a cock that had not been touched in far, far too long. Desire that he had not felt since he was a much younger horse – too young for deeds done – flared through his veins like wildfire, potent in its intoxication. As the black stallion held up his paws and backed away, embarrassed, Pax crept closer, ducking under the barbell with his eyes firmly fixed on the stallion’s bulge.

It was crazy. He should have left. He should have laughed it off with Diego as a mishap at the gym, pulled the stallion back to a safe, level playing field with him. And then he didn’t.

“Ah, I’m sorry...” Diego rubbed his muzzle. “I know I was helping you and all, but you just put yourself in such position there... Can’t help but notice your physique, colt. I’m not a pervert, I swear!”

Standing nose to nose, Pax pressed his lips to those of the stallion’s, lifting his arms around the horse’s neck even as Diego jerked back in shock. Pax’s lips parted, tongue questing for a new experience as he moved too quickly to consider the insanity of what he

was doing, the stranger whose bulge ground against his own. Their tongues danced together and Pax groaned into the kiss, pressing close as Diego's fingers stroked through his mane. He had lifted the weight. He could do anything.

Breaking the kiss and sharing breath, Diego's eyes shone.

"No one has to know we're here," Diego whispered with bated breath, curling his fingers into Pax's mane. "The door's locked...or will be locked. With the key on this side, of course!" He chuckled, eyes dropping longingly to Pax's crotch, bulge tenting out. "I wouldn't lock you in with no way out."

Pax quivered. In his mind's eye, he saw the black equine moving over him, cock hard and kissing the length of his own. He gasped, chin on Diego's shoulder as a shiver rant through his whole body. Why did it feel right with a male? Not an ounce of worry from his times with ladies that had no interest in him as a stallion or his pleasure, his love or his life, remained, despite the fretting tremble of his upper lip. This worry felt clean, untainted: butterflies in his stomach before a storm he wished to ride out to the very end.

Diego nuzzled into his neck and Pax's breath caught. Fast, too fast. He nickered, though could not make himself step away from the stallion's muscled warmth. Worry was one thing – he wanted this. And badly too.

"You don't have to do anything you don't want to do, colt." Diego exhaled slowly, warm breath wafting over Pax's neck, muscle twitching wherever the horse's paws roamed. "We can leave right now, or even finish our workout, if that's what you want to do. This is in your control."

The palomino snorted, shaking his mane off his neck. Every fibre of his being sang to the stallion's touch, experience thrumming through his fingertips as they grazed down Pax's side to his hips and buttocks.

"I don't know if I can do this..." Pax admitted, head rolling back as the stallion lipped at his throat, nipping the line of his jaw. "It's not that I've...ah...never had sex before...not with... Fuck, you already know that. But I've never been with a guy... I don't know what to do."

"I can teach you, colt, if that is what you want."

The stallion dropped a kiss on Pax's nose, fingers curling in to squeeze his rump, a cheeky edge to the cocky tilt of his head. Squeaking, Pax unwittingly pushed his backside into Diego's paws and the stallion smirked, tugging Pax's jogging bottoms down to his thighs. The equine whinnied as his cock sprung out, having not worn any underwear to the gym, a grey and pink mottled shaft bobbing proudly once released from the restraining fabric. Diego murmured his appreciation and licked his lips with a very pink tongue, easing to his knees.

"Oh, very nice, colt..." He brushed his lips over the head of his cock, touch velvety. "I'm going to make you feel very, very good. Just relax now, my colt."

Taking Pax's cock in one paw, he wrapped his fingers around the girth, barely making his finger and thumb meet around. The stallion wasted no time, leaning in to lap over the head, tasting pre cum and the sweet aroma of stallion musk that embodied taste and scent simultaneously. His cock throbbed, lust rising, and he parted his lips as wide as he dared to take the head of Pax's cock into his muzzle, sliding down until the head kissed the back of his throat. His tongue squeezed to the underside, rubbing and slathering the fat shaft in saliva that would be sorely needed. His eyes narrowed, cock straining against the fabric of his gym trousers. A stallion had needs as strong as a colt.

Shifting from hoof to hoof, Pax's paws wandered, finding no place to rest until drifting to Diego's head and winding lightly into his mane. His tail swished mindlessly, eyes on the show as inch after inch of his cock disappeared into a hot, willing muzzle, which was all too eager to please. He'd never known that a blowjob was meant to feel so good. His hips

bucked of their own accord, thrusting his deeper and nudging his shaft down the stallion's throat. He worried for half a second that he was making Diego uncomfortable before remembering that equines lacked a gag reflex: he'd seen it in practice.

"Ah..." Pax trembled as the stallion's lips slid nearly to the very base of his cock, tightly pursed around his length. "Aren't you going to show me...too? Pull your trousers down? You were the one getting hard, after all..." Pax blushed. "You want me as much as I want you."

He trailed off with a feeble chuckle. Diego did not pull his muzzle from Pax's cock but obliged by yanking his trousers down to his knees along with his boxer shorts to reveal a dropped pink shaft with the faintest splash of black mottling. Pax's heart leapt into his throat, cock pulsing with a spurt of pre cum that Diego gulped down, throat working around his shaft. Grunting, Diego bobbed his muzzle and took the full length down his throat, only then coming up for a quick intake of air through his nostrils, eyes lidded from pleasure. The palomino twisted his fingers more roughly into Diego's mane and bucked, tail flicking as his buttocks clenched.

So close! Pax jerked as the familiar, old rush of erotic delight tickled his senses with increasing persistence. He rolled his head from one shoulder to the other, eyes closed against the glare of unflattering overhead lights. His buttocks clenched and he tried to think of anything that may stave off the oncoming storm. His cock throbbed and Diego suckled harder as if sensing his predicament. Pax shook his head, upper lip curling back as he sifted through the scent of musky stallion, heady in the air. It was all too much, much too much. No... He had to hold out. Just a little longer. He could do it. He just wanted to enjoy a little longer.

Taking note of his sudden stillness, Diego withdrew, the flat head of Pax's cock popping from his lips and drooping under its own weight. Though he grumbled at the decrease in sensation, balanced on the brink of an explosive orgasm, he was relieved for the respite, calming with a tremble than ran the length of his body from his nose to his fetlocks. Diego flashed him a brilliant grin and dove to the side, reclaiming his own gym bag from where he had dropped it beside the half-rack. Pax blinked. It seemed like an extremely long time ago that he had been in the rack with Diego spotting him, driving him on to achieve his goals and shift the weight of the bar and all that held him back. The stallion nickered.

"Quick, colt." Diego blew him a kiss, tossing him a small, capped tube from the red bag that Pax barely reacted in time to catch. "I didn't lock the door or anything like I said I would, anyone could walk in. I know it's late and...fuck, I want you. I want you so bad, colt. Please?"

Pax wondered if Diego really even had to ask permission. Privacy seemed like a foreign concept with his cock swaying like a flagpole caught by a too strong wind. It was kind of cute to see the stronger, larger stallion on his knees begging too. It made him feel stronger.

Pax smirked, lips quirking up almost unwillingly. Cock throbbing, it twitched as blood pulsed through the length and denied a supply to more thoughtful organs that may have had better use for it. Judgement was out the window. It was a good thing that he had a guide to reassure him that his judgement was spot on; risks could be fun too. Glancing down at the bottle clasped between his paws, Pax raised an eyebrow.

"Moisturiser?" Pax chuckled and turned it over in his paws. "You sure that's going to be enough? We'd need more, right? You're kind of... Well, you're...big."

"Not for me, colt," Diego winked. "Here."

Resting his elbows on the black, padded bench, Diego rocked his rump up and wriggled his buttocks teasingly, tail flagged high to show off his tight pucker, clenching down on nothing. Pax swallowed, approaching with his cock in one paw and the moisturiser in the other, feeling as if his mind was no longer connected with his body. It was as if he had

fallen into the most wonderful of dreams, though everything was certainly real. Licking his lips nervously, Pax squeezed a generous dose of creamy white moisturiser on to his cock and spread it along the whole length, adding more and more so that it did not simply soak into his mottled grey and pink skin.

“And...you’ll be okay?”

Pax bit his tongue, eyes wide. He had to ask, for the stallion looked so sweet, laid out before him with his tail hiked in display. If he’d had less care and concern for the black horse, he would have mounted him right there and then, fumbled and thrust in with a stallion scream that would have alerted the entire hotel to their tryst. Peering back, Diego shot him a reassuring grin, ears swivelling to pay him every ounce of attention he had to give.

“Trust me, colt. I’ll be just fine. Better than fine.”

That would have to be reassurance enough for the golden stud. Pax rubbed his cock and stepped up to the stallion, letting his shaft drop on to Diego’s muscled buttocks. By the gods, they were perfect, swelling with years of building muscle and definition. Diego grunted as the flat cock-tip slipped between his cheeks, the stallion grinding it back and forth with a moan.

“Fuck me, colt...”

Pax had no strength with which to resist, pushing Diego’s tail up with the backs of his fingers. Holding his breath, he rubbed the well lubricated tip of his cock over the horse’s tail hole before daring to push in and bore down with the gentleness of a long-time lover. For a moment, it seemed as if the stallion was trying to keep him out, pushing against the head, and then half the length of Pax’s cock slipped in with hardly any resistance, stretching out the stallion’s tail hole. He groaned, panting heavily, and arched his back, rocking into Pax’s first steady thrust, which ground in deep until the stallion’s crotch was flush with his rump.

The black stallion grunted and flipped his tail higher, swatting Pax across the chest as he struggled to contain the pleasure wracking his body. Screwing up his muzzle, Pax pushed his chest out, vest top askew. He could have spent himself in a matter of seconds, but he wanted Diego to feel as good as he did. The stallion deserved every second of pleasure Pax could deliver and more.

“Ah...fuck, colt...” Diego whinnied, head lowered to brush his nose over the bench. “You’re thick...ah...”

“Is it too much? I can pull out if you want. I don’t want to hurt you.”

Pax didn’t want to pull out but would if he had no other option. Diego, however, shook his head, mane falling to the left side of his neck.

“No, colt... Fuck me. Good and deep.”

Paws on Diego’s hips, Pax took him at his word and thrust, learning the first nuances of male pleasure with a light-headed moan. His cock disappeared again and again into the stallion’s rump, each thrust feeling as if it was the very first all over again. Would that this was his first time!

Pax rolled his shoulders backwards, fingers groping the fine stallion’s arse. How did anyone bear such sensation? A hot, clenching hole around his rod, dragging him in more and more with every thrust? And, below the stallion’s belly hung an equally delicious pole of flesh, drooling pre cum in a pool down to the floor. The cleaners would have fun the next morning, he had no doubt about that. Gasping, Pax drove in harder and deeper, just as Diego asked, glutes clenching to add more power to his thrusts. The rhythm came naturally to him, as if he had been born to do it. Having the stallion beneath him was inherently right. Though he wondered one thing as Diego moaned and arched back, whinnying for more.

What would that cock feel like under *his* tail?

Rutting, the stallion’s nickered and ground together, Pax’s hips slapping into Diego’s rump with every thrust. Their whinnies rose, blending together into one, as sweat beaded on

Pax's coat. Diego didn't seem to notice droplets landing on his back, splattering his t-shirt, head ducked down over the other side of the bench as he pushed his hips up as far towards Pax as was physically possible in the position. He splayed his legs apart for balance, grunting every time Pax thrust in, the palomino getting into the act and pounding his tail hole with enough force to send a throb of soreness through his tail hole.

It would all be worth it, for those moments alone.

Pax closed his eyes against the gym lights, obnoxiously glancing off Diego's coat, and tucked his chin down to his chest. It was unlike anything he had ever felt before, to have a stallion bucking beneath him, eager for every inch he had to give. And, with so much pleasure, came the roar of an unstoppable force that not even the best of intentions could hold back behind the flood gates for more than a few heartbeats. Gripping Diego's tail, Pax neighed and hammered in, hips driving in short, unforgiving thrusts that made the stallion quake.

It was too late for Pax – needs overcame desire and he snapped his eyes open, nostrils sharply flared for a last intake of breath before his world lost focus. He slammed in, losing himself in the moment, and ejaculated with a stallion scream of release, falling over the larger horse and letting the equine support his entire weight as his cock throbbed, filling his tail hole with thick spurts of cum. Pulsing more and more until Pax feared orgasm would drain him dry, steal every last drop from his sore balls, he thrust weakly until stallion cum drooled from the stallion's ring, forced out along his length.

Diego was not to go forgotten, however, and Pax wearily lipped at the base of his neck, reaching around the stallion's cut abdomen – abs against the back of his paw – to stroke his cock with quick, untrained pumps. The stallion grunted, flagged his tail and arched against him, head shooting up to press his cheek to Pax's as the head of his cock flared dramatically, pre cum leaking in a steady stream in prelude to climax. Rocking his head to the side, Diego gave a gasp that shuddered through him as he reached orgasm, swift to cum as a cock softened under his tail. His whole body trembled as his balls tightened up to his body, just that fraction, and he dropped his chest completely to the bench with Pax on top of him, cock shooting cum to paint the floor for an impressive distance as pleasure ripped any remaining notion of hiding their liaison in the gym from his mind.

Struggling to turn his head far enough around, cock still spurting, Diego nuzzled Pax, sharing a brief kiss before he had to hang his muzzle low once more. Breath came with difficulty and Pax pulled his paws to the bench, taking some of the weight off his partner as his tail waved high, covering Diego's shoulders in kisses and nips even as his arms trembled.

"Mmmph, you really are something special, colt..."

Pax pressed his muzzle into the back of Diego's neck, for the first time in his young life, completely and utterly content. He only wished that the night did not have to end. And it didn't, if not for a little while. For a time, they had each other and could recover in each other's arms. If Pax was lucky, perhaps there would even be a round two. A colt could dream.

He held the stallion tighter, hiding the single tear squeezed from the corner of his eye.

Thank you.

*

Packing his bags in the hotel room the next morning, Pax's mind wandered from his sister's constant chatter of the night before, much too late for him to take in comprehensibly. She said he had missed so much out at the roulette tables and slot machines but, in all honesty, he couldn't see what he had missed at all. More than ever before, he felt secure in who he was and he knew where he wanted to go and what he wanted to do with his life. He would attend university. He would do a joint honours degree, a little safety net in the sciences

with options open to him. He had a life ahead of him and renewed certainty in who he was. It didn't matter what anyone else thought. He knew that now. But lessons had to be learned for oneself.

In his holdall bag was a business card with a certain horse's phone number scrawled across the back in scratchy pen, the ink half-dying. During the early neon hours of the morning, while Sera snored off her drink, he had cast his eyes over and over that number, unable to fathom just how he had been lucky enough to acquire it. He had not even seen the stallion slip it into the pocket of his jogging bottoms as they left the gym, a wily trickster indeed while Pax had been too shy to ask for it when they shared a goodbye kiss that had turned into lust, dragging one another back to Pax's room. Though it was more than impressive, in his eyes, that an equine of Diego's size had been able to slip anything into him at all.

Pax's lips twisted as he blushed at the memories, the hot stallion pressing him down into the bed, rushed and clumsy in fear of his sister returning, hours after they had left the gym. But there was more to their liaison than sex alone, a kindling of hope that Pax held close to his heart.

Looking out the window to the bright sunshine, Pax smiled and hauled the bag up on to his shoulder, heavy with belongings snuck into the holdall by his oh so lovely sister. She wasn't so bad after all. Sera hadn't meant any harm, though she refused to account for any harm. He would only have to be strong enough to work through it, with a side of help. His new 'friend' taught him that. And perhaps his family would accept him regardless of their inclinations towards mares who loved cats and stallions who loved stallions. They loved him – he knew that. He would not know unless he tried, unless he took that leap into the unknown and tackled the aftermath in his stride. The stallion would be prepared for everything and anything.

Although he would not tell his family of Diego for many more years to come, the Spanish stallion and how he stole his heart, cliché even in his warm, brown eyes, there were many more good things in life to come, experience and days to make him feel alive. The furs walking through life with him were what made it life and he shuddered at the memory of Diego's arms wrapped around him, holding him protectively close as he trembled. He yearned to feel those arms tight around him again, muscle flexing. Diego could protect him as he could look after the stallion too. Yes, experiences were the fuel of life itself. It was those very experiences, risks and love giggled over in the dawn, that made life worth living. He could not have learned that at a better time. A few days later and it could have all been too late for a life cast away and locked in disarray.

He was a lucky 'colt' indeed.

His smile too wide to contain, Pax opened the hotel room door and stepped out to greet the rest of his life, phone clutched in his paw to dial a number that he had already memorised. Holding his breath, he trotted down the corridor, ignoring the looks from the hotel cleaner as he bounded over her red plastic caddy of supplies, a duster clutched in the older husky's gloved paw. It didn't matter what looks he got when all his attention was on the phone ringing, Pax's heart pounding like a runaway steam engine.

The phone stopped ringing and the stallion exhaled a breath he had not known he had been holding, slowing to a much needed halt outside the lift. A familiar stallion nickered down the line.

"Hey."